

“We **shoot** with **bows** and **hurl** **javelins** and **ride horses**.”

AMAZON WARRIORS.
HERODOTUS' *HISTORIES*, 440 BCE

THROUGH THE AGES

Warfare

Throughout ancient and medieval history, women seldom fought in battles in large numbers. However, while warfare was predominantly a male activity, across many cultures exceptional individual women fought on the battlefield—and a handful even led armies of their own.



ALTHOUGH WOMEN WARRIORS were rare, the war goddess features repeatedly across the world's mythologies. In ancient Egyptian lore, Sekhmet appeared in the form of a fierce lioness and protected the pharaoh in battle, while in the Hindu pantheon, Durga is often shown riding a tiger and clutching weapons in her ten hands, valiantly fighting the forces of evil. The Amazons are perhaps the best-known female warrior figures, and are immortalized in Greek legends.

◀ Pictish woman

In the time of the Roman Empire, Scottish tribes had both male and female warriors. The Romans called them "Picti," or "painted ones," due to the fighters' body decorations.

▶ Warlike women

A bronze sculpture of an Amazon warrior conveys the athletic strength and skill the legendary tribe were said to possess.



A tribe of warlike women, they cut off their right breasts to fire their bows and throw their javelins better, but protected their left breasts so that they could breastfeed their babies.

Though such fighting women were mythological, they are thought to have some basis in reality. The Amazon myth may have been founded on the Scythians, a nomadic people from Central Asia who migrated to Eastern Europe by the 7th century BCE. They fought on horseback and were highly skilled with the bow. Archaeological analysis of Scythian burial mounds has found that over one-third of female remains were interred with weapons and their bones showed evidence of fighting, suggesting their warriors were women.

Asia's most famous legendary female fighter was Hua Mulan, who is said to have lived in China in the 4th or 5th century CE. Disguised as a man, she joined the army and fought for over a decade. She was promoted to general,